



MEXICO

Capital city: Mexico City

Area: 761,602 sq miles
(1,972,550 sq km)

Population: 98,900,000

Official language:
SpanishMajor religions: Christian
93%, other 7%Government: Multiparty
democracyCurrency: Mexico
new peso

Adult literacy rate: 91%

Life expectancy: 74 years

People per doctor: 667

Televisions: 261 per
1,000 people

MEXICO

THE COLORFUL LAND OF MEXICO was once home to the golden civilizations of the Maya and Aztecs. These ancient empires were destroyed by the Spanish, who invaded in the 1500s and ruled the country until its independence in 1821. Descendants of the native peoples still live in Mexico, but most people are *mestizo*, of mixed Spanish and native Indian descent. Almost half of all Mexicans are under 19 years old, and the population is growing rapidly, leading to overcrowding in the cities. Mexico has limited farmland and cannot produce enough food for the growing population.

SIGHT-SEEING

Tourism is one of Mexico's biggest sources of income. Visitors from all over the world come to see Chichén Itzá, Tenochtitlán, Palenque, and other sites of the ancient Maya and Aztec civilizations.

The warm sea and sandy beaches at coastal resorts, such as Acapulco and Cancun, also attract many tourists.

These buildings at Teotihuacán, near Mexico City, are the remains of an ancient religious center.



Most Mexicans are Roman Catholic and worship in churches often named after saints.

Women carry decorated baskets of flowers. They wear wraparound skirts, called enrados, and white blouses.

Men parade with large cotton globes on which the name of their town is written.



VILLAGE FESTIVALS

Festivals, or *fiestas*, are a common part of Mexican village life. Each village has its own patron saint and on the saint's day there is a colorful celebration. There are 115 separate saints' days in Mexico. Here the people of a small town near Oaxaca celebrate their *fiesta* with a street procession. Although most people in Mexico are Roman Catholic, native Indian beliefs are also important, and many festivals are a mixture of Christian and Indian traditions.



A LAND OF CONTRASTS

Mexico's landscape ranges from vast deserts in the north, through snowcapped mountains and a central plateau in the center, to tropical rain forests in the south. The Sonoran Desert, shown here, stretches across the border into the US. This desert is home to the giant saguaro cactus and to poisonous animals such as rattlesnakes and scorpions.



Mexico City's most famous street is the wide Paseo de la Reforma, with its tall buildings, cafés, and theaters.

MEXICO CITY

With a population of more than 22 million, Mexico City is one of the world's largest cities. But its size and location create many problems. It lies at a high altitude and is ringed by mountains, so pollution from cars and factories cannot escape and poisons the air. Children often wait to leave for school until after rush hour to avoid car fumes. Mexico City is very overcrowded, and the area is prone to earthquakes; the most recent one devastated the city center in 1985.

A dip called guacamole is made with avocados.

Beer with a slice of lime



Avocado

Chilies

Tortillas are eaten like bread or made into a snack called a taco.

MEXICAN FOOD

Mexicans eat a variety of spicy foods flavored with chilies. Most of the food is based on home-grown produce, such as avocados, beans, tomatoes, and corn. Pancakes, called tortillas, are made from corn flour and filled with meat or vegetables, and cheese. Cooks also mix chilies and chocolate to make a spicy sauce called *mole*, which is served on chicken.